
The Morning: Running late

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The New York Times
The Morning

May 9, 2026



Good morning. Why does it feel worse to be early than to rush and stress and arrive a little late?



María Jesús Contreras

Early adopter



By **Melissa Kirsch**

If my mother has plans for dinner, she's ready to go by lunchtime — showered and dressed, hair and makeup done. The apple has fallen very far from the tree in this regard, fallen and rolled down the hill into a puddle where, I fear, it rots. I am constantly running late, frittering away every last second before departure, leaving myself on average five minutes too few to get presentable. I am usually late by a few minutes, nothing outrageous, but this “respectable” tardiness is achieved only through chaotic rushing, sometimes jogging the last few blocks to the restaurant.

Rushing, I've found, is [the root of much of the misery](#) of modern life. Why would one persist in behavior that brings on misery? I seem to have developed the irrational opinion that being early is worse than rushing. This sounds ridiculous. But I've observed myself, rich with multiple unscheduled hours before an engagement, defiantly do nothing to prepare myself for said engagement until 19 minutes before departure. Nineteen minutes, in my

delusional calculations, feels somehow like just enough time to shower, dress and hit the road. Here, in clearheaded reflection, I know this is folly.

When I think about being ready with time to spare, I feel almost queasy. Once I'm ready, I must rush out the door. I can't be ready and then, say, water the plants, or sit down and read a book. I'm ready! Let's go! When I imagine arriving someplace early, instead of envisioning a leisurely trip, a few minutes to collect myself before others arrive, I see myself unmoored, standing awkwardly and in the way. The maitre d' asks me to wait over by the coats until the rest of my party arrives. Being early, according to my fool's logic, results in discomfort and shame.

When I asked my mother why she gets ready so early, she explained, "Then I don't have to worry about it." Getting ready is an item on a to-do list, and once she checks it off, she can move on with the rest of her day.

I wonder if the modern fixation with productivity, with using every minute, has affected us both in different ways. My mother wants to get the chore done so she doesn't have it hanging over her. I fear the loose, unstructured minutes that being early creates. I am so used to time being scarce, to feeling accomplishment when I cram as much as possible into a given day, that I create scarcity even when there isn't any.

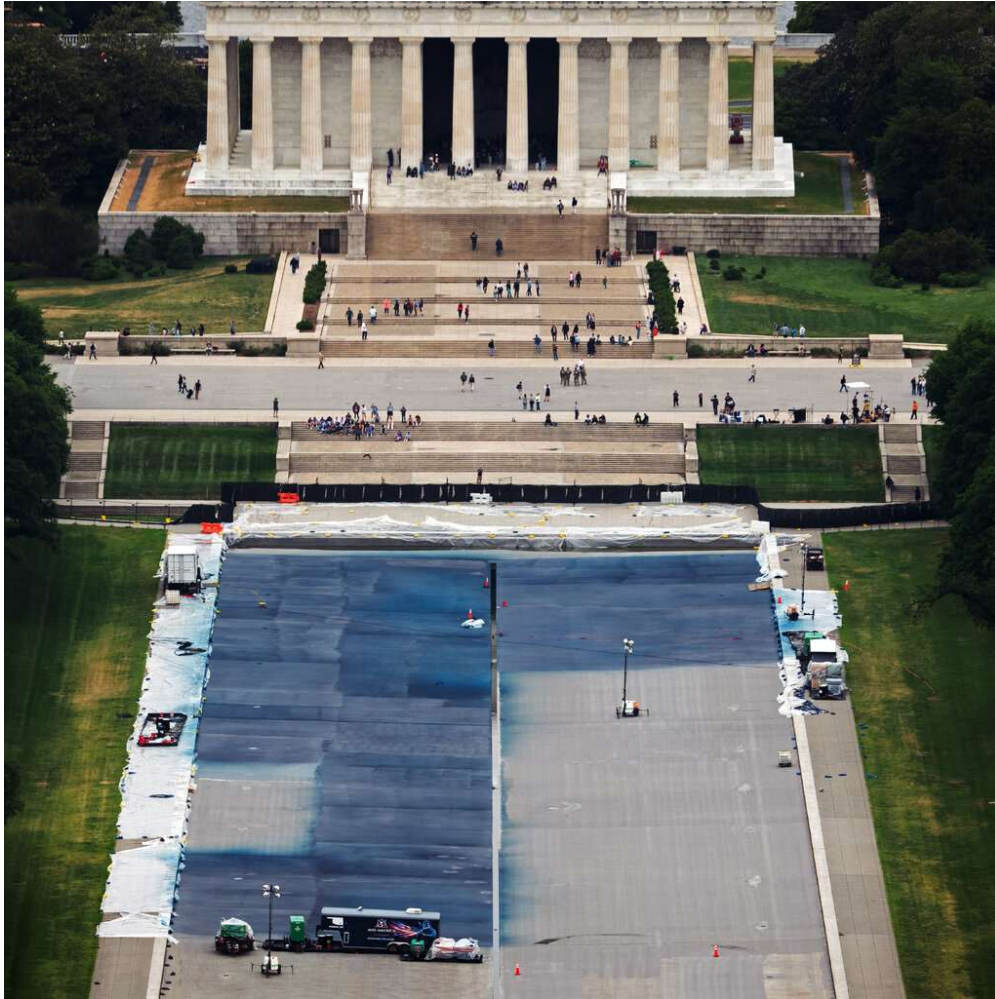
I read this [lovely meditation on time](#) from a few years ago in which the writer Yohanca Delgado suggests looking to geologic time in an effort to recontextualize our commitment to hustle culture. "What if obsessively keeping time matters less than we think it does when we consider the time scale of the cosmos?" she writes. When you're measuring time in the billions of years, those few unstructured minutes one must endure when arriving early recede in importance.

I'm planning to do an "early experiment" over the next few weeks, where I fight every impulse I have to run out the clock, where I make myself arrive at least 15 minutes early for every obligation. I want to see what happens if I sit with the uncertainty of extra time. What if the relief I get from not rushing is so delicious that I am able to break the habit? "Better three hours too soon than a minute too late," Shakespeare wrote in "The Merry Wives of Windsor." I'll admit this sounds more like punishment than wisdom, but I intend to find out.



THE LATEST

Politics



Allison Robbert for The New York Times

President Trump decided [to paint Washington's reflecting pool "American flag blue"](#) — and then gave out a \$6.9 million no-bid government contract to a firm he said had worked on his swimming pools.

Trump has approved a plan to [fire the F.D.A. commissioner](#), Dr. Marty Makary, according to a person briefed on the matter.

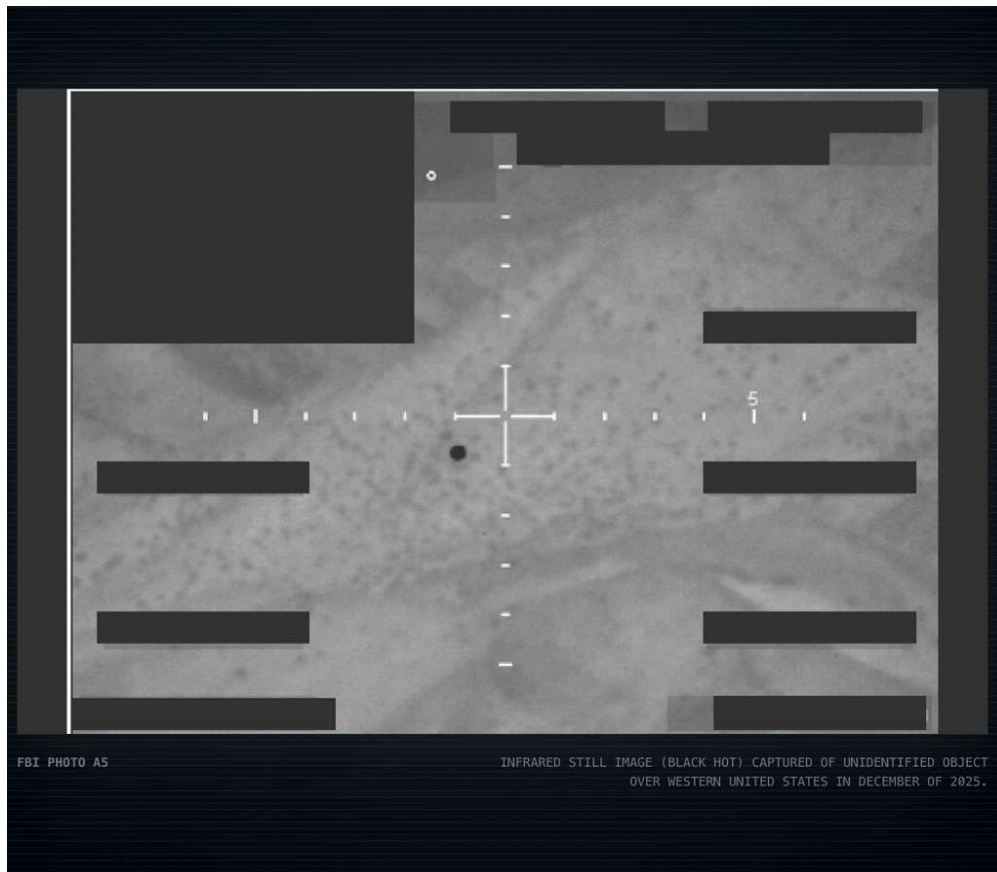
The Trump administration asked courts [to revoke 12 immigrants' citizenship](#), signaling that it plans to ramp up denaturalizations, which have rarely happened in the past.

A Virginia court [struck down the state's new congressional map](#). The ruling wipes out four new Democratic-leaning districts, which voters approved in a referendum last month.

ABC accused the F.C.C. [of violating its free speech rights](#), potentially setting the stage for a legal fight with the Trump administration.

The U.S. fired at [two more oil tankers](#) that it said were trying to reach an Iranian port. Iran accused the U.S. of undermining diplomatic efforts to end the war.

Other Big Stories



The Pentagon

The Pentagon released what it called [“new, never-before-seen” files](#) on U.F.O.s. The images are murky, however, showing little more than dots and small shapes.

Job creation in the U.S. [remained solid in April](#): Employers added 115,000 jobs last month, surpassing expectations, and the unemployment rate stayed at 4.3 percent.

In Britain’s nationwide municipal elections, the right-wing populist party [Reform U.K. picked up hundreds of seats](#), while the left-wing Labour Party suffered deep losses.

THE WEEK IN CULTURE

Venice Biennale



Matteo de Mayda for The New York Times

The Venice Biennale, the art world's most prestigious international exhibition, is underway. [See photos and videos of the art.](#)

The buzziest entry at this year's Biennale, from Austria, involves [two blue portable toilets](#) and a naked scuba diver.

Russia was allowed back into the Biennale for the first time since the country invaded Ukraine. Its pavilion featured [music and free vodka](#).

Film and TV

"The Sheep Detectives," a murder mystery featuring a talking flock of sheep, [is a delightful surprise, our critic writes](#), the sort of funny, emotionally complex PG-rated fare that has become rare in Hollywood.

The [BBC series "The Other Bennet Sister"](#) — which tells the story of "Pride and Prejudice" from the perspective of Mary, the overlooked middle sister — is the most-watched new drama of the past year in Britain. It's now streaming on BritBox.

TV shows of old often used menopause as a punchline. Newer series like "Your Friends & Neighbors" and "Riot Women" [depict it as a matter-of-fact part of life](#).

More Culture

Kid Cudi [fired the singer M.I.A. from his tour](#) after she veered into a political rant about illegal immigration at a concert in Dallas.

Barack Obama, Kim Kardashian and Bowen Yang have all signed on as co-producers of Broadway shows. In the video below, our theater reporter Michael Paulson explains why. **Click to play.**



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CULTURE CALENDAR



By [Alexis Soloski](#)

💖 ✂️ **‘Outlander’ (Friday):** Get ready for a little less tartan in your life, as “Outlander,” the passionate historical time-travel series, concludes its final season on Starz. A story of an English nurse (Caitriona Balfe) who slips from the mid-20th century to the mid-18th, where she meets and marries the Highland warrior Jamie Fraser (Sam Heughan), the show took its characters across nations and in and out of wars as it wove their love story. Before “Bridgerton,” before “Heated Rivalry,” it made a case for romance on television. For those with swooning withdrawal, a second season of the spinoff, “Outlander: Blood of My Blood,” debuts in the fall.



REAL ESTATE



Jeff and Cindy Gilliland Jonathan Zizzo for The New York Times

The Hunt: A retired couple left Dallas for Denton, Texas, in search of a single-story house where their family could gather. What did they find? [Play our game.](#)

What you get for [\\$1.8 million in Budapest](#): A duplex penthouse in the heart of the city. A three-bedroom condo in a leafy neighborhood. A four-bedroom house with a terraced garden.

First-time buyers: Even in a tough housing market, there are cities where owning a home is no more expensive than renting. [Here are some of them.](#)



Beverly Brown has been living out of her camper van since 2019. Whitney Curtis for The New York Times

Life on wheels: For a growing number of retirees, trading a home for an R.V. is a way to find adventure, [and financial freedom](#).

Landscaping: Before you get out the shovel and trowel to refresh your flower beds, learn [the right way to mulch](#).

ADVICE FROM WIRECUTTER

What even is a passkey?

Passkeys are a new technology that securely logs you in, without your having to remember a password or perform a two-factor authentication ritual. They aren't perfect — and we're still a ways off from their being commonplace — but [learning what a passkey is and how to use it](#) can get us a little closer to a more secure future. You can create one on your device, in a password manager or on a [physical security key](#). Once you do, your accounts can only be unlocked after authentication via a PIN, facial recognition or a fingerprint scan. In a world of evolving scams, they're a critical defense against credential theft. — *Max Eddy*

GAME OF THE WEEK



Justin Casterline/Getty Images

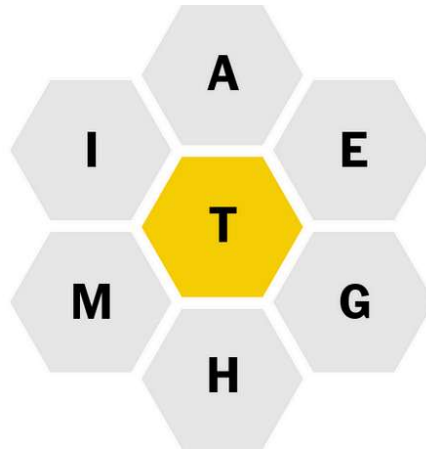
Dallas Wings vs. Indiana Fever, W.N.B.A.: The season has just begun, and what better way to kick things off than with this showcase of young stars? The past four No. 1 draft picks are all here — Caitlin Clark and Aliyah Boston on the Fever, Paige Bueckers and Azzi Fudd on the Wings. The Athletic’s experts are high on Bueckers in particular, placing her on the First Team in their [preseason All W.N.B.A. rankings](#). Last year, as a rookie, she was the only player in the league to finish in the top 10 in points, assists and steals.

As a team, however, The Athletic rates Indiana above Dallas — especially now that Clark has recovered from the injuries that kept her off the court for most of last season. “Without Clark, the Fever were on the doorstep of a finals appearance,” Sabreena Merchant and Annie Costabile [wrote this week in No Offseason](#), their new women’s basketball newsletter. “With her back, do they break through?”

Today at 1 p.m. Eastern on ABC.

[Sign up here to get No Offseason in your inbox.](#)

NOW TIME TO PLAY



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangrams were *glaciology*, *illogically* and *logically*.

[Take the news quiz](#) to see how well you followed this week's headlines.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Crossplay](#), [Connections](#) and [Strands](#).

***Thanks for spending part of your weekend with The Times. —
Melissa***

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